



GUATEMALA

Capital city: Guatemala City
Area: 42,042 sq miles (108,890 sq km)
Population: 12,300,000
Official language: Spanish
Major religions: Christian 98%, other 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Quetzal
Adult literacy rate: 70%
Life expectancy: 65 years
People per doctor: 1,111
Televisions: 126 per 1,000 people

BELIZE

Capital city: Belmopan
Area: 8,867 sq miles (22,966 sq km)
Population: 256,000
Official language: English
Major religion: Christian 87%, other 13%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Belizean dollar
Adult literacy rate: 77%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 2,000
Televisions: 183 per 1,000 people

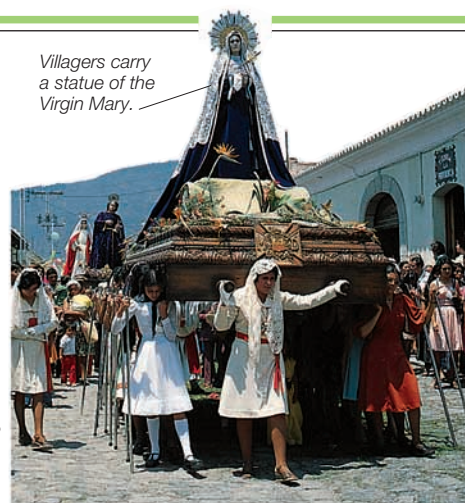
GUATEMALA

FROM THE RUINED CITIES of the ancient Mayan civilization to the Catholic churches of the Spanish, Guatemala represents a blend of cultures. Today, more than half the people are direct descendants of the Mayan Indians and live mainly in highland villages; the remainder of the population is part Indian and part Spanish. Many Mayans work for rich landowners who grow the coffee, sugar, and bananas that are the country's main cash crops. Guatemala also exports fresh-cut flowers, mostly roses, which are grown in the valleys around Antigua.

MARKET DAY

Markets such as this one in Chichicastenango, in the highlands near Lake Atitlán, are a feature of daily life. Many native Guatemalans farm small plots of land where they grow corn, beans, and squash, as well as fruit. They regularly walk long distances from outlying villages to a market to sell crops, flowers, and handcrafted goods such as pottery and baskets.

Villagers carry a statue of the Virgin Mary.



HOLY WEEK

Most Guatemalans are Roman Catholic, the religion the Spanish brought with them in the 16th century. However, many people are now becoming Protestant. Guatemalans also practice their own form of worship based on traditional beliefs. This procession in Antigua forms part of their celebration of Holy Week.

People worship Catholic saints and ancient gods at the Church of Santo Tomas.

Lilies and roses, as well as carnations and gladioli, are grown in the valleys. Many are sold to North America.

Village women wear brightly colored ankle-length skirts. Patterns date back hundreds of years.

Goods are weighed in a simple, handheld balance.

Corn and other cereals are the main foods.

Mayan craft products, such as baskets and handwoven textiles, are popular with tourists.

A basket of papayas

Avocados have been cultivated in Central America for thousands of years.

WEAVING STYLES

Weaving is a traditional craft. Cloth is made from colored yarn, using patterns that have been handed down through the generations. There are more than 300 different styles, each with a special historical meaning.

Weavers use a backstrap loom that can be moved from place to place.



CITIES OF THE MAYA

Tourism is one of Guatemala's fastest growing industries. Each year almost one million tourists visit the country to see its ancient sites. Spectacular ruins mark the site of Tikal, one of the great Mayan cities. Tikal was mysteriously abandoned in about AD 900. Today its ruined temples lie in a huge area of tropical forest.